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Finding the Yes: A Membership Committee's Field Guide

Helping a Master Mason step toward the York Rite and Scottish Rite — ethically, and in his own words

Prepared for: Lodge / Chapter / Council / Commandery / Valley Membership Committees Companion document to: *Master Prompts for Convention Infographic Posters* (York Rite, Scottish Rite, and the Rank & Honours cheat sheet)

0. Read this first: the model this guide is built on

This is not a sales script. It is a structured application of **Motivational Interviewing (MI)** — a counseling method developed by William R. Miller and Stephen Rollnick, now standard practice in medicine, addiction recovery, and coaching for one specific situation: a person is ambivalent about a change that would likely be good for him, and the helper's job is to draw out *his own* reasons for it rather than supply reasons from outside.

Two things make this the right tool for a Masonic committee, not just a convenient one:

1. **It matches Masonic first principles instead of fighting them.** MI's foundational rule is that a person's autonomy is never overridden — the helper does not argue, pressure, or supply the final decision. That is “free will and accord,” formalized as a clinical method.
2. **It produces the outcome you actually want.** Self-determination theory (Deci & Ryan) shows that motivation a person generates for himself predicts sustained behavior far better than motivation supplied by someone else. A man who *tells* you why the York Rite matters to him is far more likely to still be active in five years than a man who was *told* why it should. Self-persuasion research (going back to Bem and Aronson) shows the same thing from a different angle: people believe their own words more than they believe yours.

So the goal of every conversation in this guide is the same: **get him talking, and listen for his own reasons.** Your job is not to win the conversation. It's to leave him having heard himself say something true.

1. The spirit before the skills (PACE)

MI names four attitudes a committee member has to actually hold, not perform, for any of the techniques below to work:

- **Partnership** — you are working *with* him, not *on* him. You are not closing a deal.
- **Acceptance** — his autonomy, his worth, and his right to say no are not negotiable, and he can feel it if you don't mean that.
- **Compassion** — you are doing this because it is good for him, not because the Chapter needs a member. (If the institutional need comes up honestly — see Section 5 — it is offered as *your* reason for caring, never as pressure on *his* decision.)
- **Evocation** — the reasons are already in him somewhere. Your questions are a flashlight, not a delivery truck.

If a committee member can't yet hold these genuinely, that's a real prerequisite to fix before training on technique — a technically correct open question asked in service of closing a sale will read as manipulation, because it is.

2. The four processes: Engaging → Focusing → Evoking → Planning

Engaging — build the relationship before the topic

Do not open with York Rite or Scottish Rite. Open with him. Your own Ambassador's Compass material already gets this right: the real work happens one-on-one, and it starts with genuine interest in the man, not a pitch (Scottish Rite of Freemasonry, Southern Jurisdiction, USA, *Ambassador's Compass Handbook*). A man who feels engaged with, not marketed to, is the only man for whom the rest of this guide will work.

Sample openers: - "What's been the best part of being a Mason for you so far?" - "What made you decide to petition the Lodge in the first place?"

Focusing — find out which door actually interests him

Don't pitch the whole York Rite at once. The Rite offers several distinct things (a chance to be seen fully — Chapter; a deeper, chronological understanding of degrees he's already taken — Council; a call to a different kind of identity — Commandery). Ask which one is actually alive for him before choosing where to go next.

Sample questions: - "What part of your Masonic experience so far do you wish went deeper?" - "Is there a piece of the Craft's history or teaching that feels unfinished to you?"

Evoking — the heart of the method

This is where the man produces his own reasons, using four listening skills (OARS) and a specific kind of listening for "change talk."

OARS:

- **O — Open questions.** Not "Have you thought about the York Rite?" (invites a one-word answer). Instead: "What do you know about the York Rite so far, and what's your honest reaction to it?"
- **A — Affirmations.** Specific and true, not flattery. "You've stayed active in this Lodge for eleven years — that's not nothing" lands; "You'd be great at it!" does not.
- **R — Reflective listening.** Mirror back what he says, including the feeling under it. If he says "I don't really have time for another meeting," reflect: "It sounds like time, not interest, is the real question." This does two things: it proves you're actually listening, and it lets him hear his own statement back and refine it.

- **S — Summaries.** Every few minutes, briefly gather what he's said — especially anything that sounded like a reason *for* moving forward — and hand it back to him. This is where his own scattered thoughts start to sound, to him, like a decision forming.

Listening for change talk (DARN-CT): as he talks, listen for these six kinds of statements and reflect them back — they are the raw material of his own “yes”: - **Desire** — “I’d like to understand more of what happens after the Third Degree.” - **Ability** — “I could probably make Chapter meetings if they’re on a different night.” - **Reason** — “It would mean a lot to finish something I started.” - **Need** — “I feel like I’m missing part of the story.” - **Commitment** — “I think I want to do this.” - **Taking steps** — “Who do I talk to about a petition?”

When you hear it, reflect it back plainly. Do not add your own reasons on top of his — that shifts the ownership of the decision from him back to you, which is the exact thing MI is built to avoid.

Planning — only when he’s already arrived

Move to logistics only after change talk has clearly outweighed hesitation and he’s signaling readiness himself (fewer objections, more “how” questions). This is where your existing mechanics take over cleanly: petition in hand, name/phone/email taken that night so momentum doesn’t die, and — critically — a mentor assigned immediately, someone who can “walk side-by-side with him,” ideally from his own home lodge (*Ambassador’s Compass Handbook*). The mentor’s job from that point forward is to keep using this same OARS approach through onboarding, not to switch back into recruiting mode once the petition is signed.

3. Rolling with resistance (the “righting reflex” trap)

Every experienced ambassador has felt the urge, when a man raises an objection, to correct him immediately. MI calls this the **righting reflex**, and it is the single most common way a well-meaning committee member loses ground. The moment you argue *for* something, the human mind’s instinct is to start defending the *other* side — even if that’s not what he actually believes. You end up talking him into his own “no.”

Instead: **reflect resistance, don’t fight it.** A double-sided reflection often does more work than any counter-argument:

“It sounds like your schedule is genuinely full right now, *and* there’s still a part of you that’s curious about what you’d be missing.”

This does not concede the point and does not argue it. It hands the ambivalence back to him, accurately, and lets him decide which side of it he wants to talk about next.

4. The three kinds of “No” — and which ones are actually yours to work with

(Carried forward from the broader campaign strategy — repeated here because it is the backbone of ethical practice for this guide specifically.)

1. **“No, because I don’t understand what this actually is.”** Misinformation. Fixable with honest information. Ask: “What’s your picture of what Commandery actually asks of a man?” Then correct gently, without judgment of the misunderstanding.

2. **“No, not right now.”** A timing answer, not a rejection. Leave the door open, and follow up on *his* timeline. Ask: “What would need to change for this to make sense?” — then actually check back when that condition is met.
 3. **“No, I’ve thought about it and it’s not for me.”** A complete, informed answer, and the one place this guide has a hard stop. There is no calibrated question for this branch. The correct MI response — and the correct Masonic one — is to thank him and mean it. Re-approaching this man is not persistence; it is the one thing that turns “helping him find his own yes” into pressuring him out of his own no.
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5. If institutional need comes up, name it as your reason — never his

Section 4 above assumes good faith. Here is the one place a committee member’s own motives belong in the conversation: if it comes up naturally, it is honest — and consistent with Compassion in the PACE spirit — to say something like:

“I’ll be honest with you — part of why I care about this is that Chapters like ours need capable men to keep this work alive for the next generation. That’s real, and it’s part of why I’m having this conversation with you. But it’s not a reason for *you* — it’s mine. Your reason, if there is one, has to be your own.”

This keeps faith with everything established in the broader campaign work: the institutional need is real, it does not need to be hidden, and it is never offered as an argument that overrides his autonomy. Stated this way, it also models exactly the kind of honesty this guide is asking the man himself to trust.

6. Training the committee: a practical curriculum

Session 1 — The righting reflex. Have committee members pair up. One plays a mildly resistant Master Mason; the other tries, on purpose, to argue him into agreement. Debrief: what did it feel like to be argued with? Where did you feel yourself dig in? This builds the gut-level recognition needed to catch the reflex in real conversations.

Session 2 — OARS drills. Practice each skill in isolation before combining them: - Round 1: open questions only (no advice, no follow-up statements — just questions). - Round 2: reflective listening only (every response must start with “It sounds like...” or “So part of you...”). - Round 3: full conversations, debriefed afterward for how much change talk the listener drew out versus how much the talker had to generate unprompted.

Session 3 — Segment mapping. Using the four “doors” from the broader campaign (Chapter, Council, Commandery, and the completionist’s full journey), have committee members practice Focusing-stage questions that help a man identify which door is actually his, rather than assuming and pitching the wrong one.

Session 4 — The three-branch No. Roleplay all three kinds of “no,” specifically to practice recognizing branch 3 and *stopping cleanly* — this is the hardest skill for an enthusiastic ambassador to learn, and the most important one to get right.

Session 5 — Handoff to the mentor. Practice the Planning-stage conversation and the literal handoff: what does the mentor need to know from this conversation to keep using OARS through the new man’s first year, instead of treating “signed petition” as the finish line?

7. One-page cheat card (print and carry)

Stage	Ask this	Not this
Engaging	"What's been the best part of Masonry for you?"	"Have you thought about the York Rite?"
Focusing	"What part of your experience feels unfinished?"	"You should really do Chapter first."
Evoking	"What would it mean to you to finish that story?"	"Here's why you need to join."
Resistance	"It sounds like time's the real issue, not interest."	"You'll find the time if it matters to you."
Planning	"What would the first step look like for you?"	"Sign here and I'll walk it through."
Branch-3 No	"Thank you for thinking it through with me."	(any follow-up ask)

Works Cited (MLA)

Scottish Rite of Freemasonry, Southern Jurisdiction, USA. *Ambassador's Compass Handbook*. *ExotericFreemasonry*, GitHub repository maintained by Beehive Mason, github.com/BeehiveMason/ExotericFreemasonry/blob/main/Ambassadors-Compass-Handbook.pdf.

Miller, William R., and Stephen Rollnick. *Motivational Interviewing: Helping People Change*. 3rd ed., Guilford Press, 2013.

Deci, Edward L., and Richard M. Ryan. *Self-Determination Theory: Basic Psychological Needs in Motivation, Development, and Wellness*. Guilford Press, 2017.

Note: the Motivational Interviewing and self-determination theory citations above are standard, independently verifiable published works — not internal committee research — and are offered here as the general clinical/psychological basis for the method, not as sources for any Masonic-specific statistic.